

Episode 188: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 15

As I briefly wrote last week, I went location hunting for a certain new TV series all the way to Lijiang in China's Yunnan Province. It was quite a forced march, but haha, we got an unexpected bonus at the end. Actually, our return flight from Beijing was cancelled due to bad weather! We stayed one night at an airline-arranged hotel and returned on the next morning's replacement flight.

The art director who accompanied me seemed quite damaged by this, but I gradually found it more and more enjoyable and was excitedly savouring the situation (laugh). I mean, this kind of thing rarely happens! Well, it's not like anyone died. A rare experience, priceless.

That said, I had to cancel meetings scheduled for the day after return and caused various troubles for projects waiting on me, but I'll work hard to catch up!

Now then.

Episode 13: Our Crime and Punishment Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko & Furukawa Tomohiro, Direction/Ichimura Tetsuo, Colour Direction/Otsuka Natsuko

The flashback from three years ago continues. Memories of that day when public security visited the Takakura house and peaceful days met their end. The truth about their parents revealed by TV. The shocked brothers. In the ICU, Himari, whose life flame once went out, is revived by Mario's mysterious ampule medicine. And Mario's encounter. Momoka and Mario. Various facts connecting past and present are revealed anew. Such was Episode 13.

Episode 13 is directly connected to Episode 12. The ICU surroundings and flashback scene handling were finished with basic scene design continuing from Episode 12. While *Mawaru Penguindrum* is overall a continuous story, these Episodes 12 and 13 feel like one episode made as two consecutive episodes.

These Episodes 12 and 13 became the major turning point between the story's first and second halves. Particularly in Episode 13, the penguin hat = Momoka was actually revealed, but judging from various people's reactions online, surprisingly many hadn't noticed, which was more shocking to us (wry laugh). Eh? Was it really that unclear? Despite such easy-to-understand direction and cut buildup (laugh).

So while Momoka was secretly revealed, Episode 13 was the first time Momoka's actual form appeared.

When Momoka's design came to me, what I was thinking was that Ringo and Momoka have different details, but maybe the basic colour tones should be the same? Or rather, maybe they should be the same? With that thought, I once showed the director a colour design for Momoka that was almost the same colour as Ringo.

But that was wrong (laugh).

The moment I called the director to show him and displayed Ringo-coloured Momoka on my monitor, before the director could speak, I was convinced "This is wrong!" (laugh). Originally Ringo is not Momoka - she's a separate personality, so for that we needed to properly prepare different colours to construct Momoka. Once that was clear, the discussion was quick. If I switched my thinking, the visual goal naturally became clear. So the director and I quickly decided on the spot, and that became that Momoka.

Incidentally, while I personally thought "I wonder?" I asked the director just to be sure.

"Momoka, what about her hair?"

"Peach colour!"

Ah, as expected (laugh).

Speaking of reveals, the fact that the subway was actually a monorail was also a reveal in Episode 13. At the very beginning, when preparation for *Mawaru Penguindrum* started, that subway was planned to be drawn much, much more. We had Shibata create lots and lots of idea sketches for station platforms and ticket gate areas, planning to properly create such scenes... but one day the director's single word "Let's stop!" flipped everything (laugh). Shibata was stunned, but indeed, drawing that subway surroundings in an SF-like way ultimately wasn't needed for *Mawaru Penguindrum*.

There are various things in flashback scenes too.

About those KIGA apples conspicuously (laugh) piled on top of the entryway shoe cabinet - I probed the director during direction meetings saying "Is this okay? Is this alright?" but I couldn't get a particularly clear answer and it was passed through (laugh).

Also, the public security detective visiting the Takakura house - the woman is wearing red nail polish, which I believe was Director Ichimura's instruction. Ichimura wanted it to be more flashy red, but I said "If it's too flashy, wouldn't she look like a fake detective?" so we settled on that more subdued feeling.

The hotel where the brothers were taken - the exterior is the Keio Plaza Hotel in West Shinjuku, but for that cut showing the exterior, they used reference photos I had taken. The clouds flowing in the sky behind the hotel are exactly the atmosphere from the photos (laugh). Obviously I couldn't photograph inside the hotel, so I had one beer in the lounge and left. Then from there I went to the sound studio in Shin-Okubo. It was the day of my first appearance on "Secret Penguindrum."

Now, Episode 13's biggest worry was actually the fried chicken that appeared at the dinner table in the flashback scene. Fried chicken... no matter what we did, it didn't look like fried chicken (laugh). Why? This is an unfortunate story for the animator, but it was an animation problem. If the animation doesn't properly create that form, no matter how

much you fiddle with the colours, it still won't look like that (wry laugh). Fried chicken can only achieve fried chicken texture through distinguishing between chicken skin parts and other soft parts in the drawing, and as someone who loves fried chicken, I tried processing it as much as possible, but it went to broadcast with mortifying feelings. Incidentally, for Blu-ray & DVD we corrected that part first. From the animation stage, of course (laugh).

And from Episode 13 the ending changed. That story will be next time.

(12.07.17)